

In face of my positive assertion, Hawes said no more. He thanked me again and left.

I had gone as far as the front door with him, and on the hall table I saw four notes. They had certain characteristics in common. The handwriting was almost unmistakably feminine; they all bore the words 'By hand, Urgent,' and the only difference I could see was that one was noticeably dirtier than the rest.

Their similarity gave me a curious feeling of seeing—not double but quadruple.

Mary came out of the kitchen and caught me staring at them.

'Come by hand since lunch time,' she volunteered. 'All but one. I found that in the box.'

I nodded, gathered them up and took them into the study.

The first one ran thus.

Dear Mr Clement,

Something has come to my knowledge which I feel you ought to know. It concerns the death of poor Colonel Protheroe. I should much appreciate your advice on the matter—whether to go to the police or not. Since my dear husband's death, I have such a shrinking from every kind of publicity. Perhaps you could run in and see me for a few minutes this afternoon,

Yours sincerely,

MARTHA PRICE RIDLEY.

I opened the second.

Dear Mr Clement,
I am so troubled—so exercised in my mind—to know what I ought to do. Something has come to my ears that I feel may be important. I have such a horror of being mixed up with the police in any way. I am so disturbed and distressed. Would it be asking too much of you, dear Vicar, to drop in for a few minutes and solve my doubts and perplexities for me in the wonderful way you always do?
Forgive my troubling you,

Yours very sincerely,

CAROLINE WETHERBY.

The third, I felt, I could almost have recited beforehand.

Dear Mr Clement,

Something most important has come to my ears. I feel you should be the first to know about it. Will you call in and see me this afternoon sometime? I will wait in for you.

This militant epistle was signed

AMANDA HARTNELL.

I opened the fourth missive. It has been my good fortune to be troubled with very few anonymous letters. An anonymous letter is, I think, the meanest and cruelest weapon there is. This one was no exception. It purported to be written by an illiterate person, but several things inclined me to disbelieve that assumption.

Dear Vicar,

i think you ought to know what is Going On. Your lady has been seen coming out of Mr Redding's cottage in a surreptitious manner. You know wot i mean. The two are Carrying On together. i think you ought to know.

A FRIEND.

I made a faint exclamation of disgust and, crumpling up the paper, tossed it into the open grate just as Griselda entered the room.

'What's that you're throwing down so contemptuously?' she asked.

'Fith,' I said.

Taking a match from my pocket, I struck it and bent down. Griselda, however, was too quick for me. She had stooped down and caught up the crumpled ball of paper and smoothed it out before I could stop her.

She read it, gave a little exclamation of disgust, and tossed it back to me, turning away as she did so. I lighted it and watched it burn.

Griselda had moved away. She was standing by the window looking out into the garden.

'Len,' she said without turning round.

'Yes, my dear.'

'I'd like to tell you something. Yes, don't stop me. I want to, please. When—when Lawrence Redding came here, I let you think that I had only known him slightly before. That wasn't true. I—I had known him rather well. In fact, before I met you, I had been rather in love with him. I think most people are with Lawrence. I was—well—absolutely silly about him at one time. I don't mean I wrote him compromising letters or anything idiotic like they do in books. But I was rather keen on him once.'

'Why didn't you tell me?' I asked.

'Oh! Because I don't know exactly except that—well, you're foolish in some ways. Just because you're so much older than I am, you think that I—well, that I'm likely to like other people. I thought you'd be tiresome, perhaps, about me and Lawrence being friends.'

'What does he want to come and see me for? I don't like it.' His voice rose shrilly. 'He spoke of dropping in again. What does it all mean? What idea do you think he has got into his head?'

'Why should you suppose he has any ulterior motive?' I asked.

'I don't like it,' repeated Hawes obstinately. 'I've never gone against *him* in any way. I never suggested that *he* was guilty—even when he accused himself. I said it seemed most incomprehensible. If I've had suspicions of anybody, it's been of Archer—never of him. Archer is a totally different proposition—a godless, irreligious ruffian. A drunken blackguard.'

'Don't you think you're being a little harsh?' I said. 'After all, we really know very little about the man.'

'A poacher, in and out of prison, capable of anything.'

'Do you really think he shot Colonel Protheroe?' I asked curiously.

Hawes has an inveterate dislike of answering 'yes' or 'no.' I have noticed it several times lately.

'Don't you think yourself, sir, that it's the only possible solution?'

'As far as we know,' I said, 'there's no evidence of any kind against him.'

'His threats,' said Hawes eagerly. 'You forget about his threats.'

I am sick and tired of hearing about Archer's threats. As far as I can make out, there is no direct evidence that he ever made any.'

'He was determined to be revenged on Colonel Protheroe. He primed himself with drink, and then shot him.'

'That's pure supposition.'

'But you will admit that it's perfectly probable?'

'No, I don't.'

'Possible, then?'

'Possible, yes.'

Hawes glanced at me sideways.

'Why don't you think it's probable?'

'Because,' I said, 'a man like Archer wouldn't think of shooting a man with a pistol. It's the wrong weapon.'

Hawes seemed taken aback by my argument. Evidently it wasn't the objection he had expected.

'Do you really think the objection is feasible?' he asked doubtfully.

'To my mind it is a complete stumbling block to Archer's having committed the crime,' I said.

I went and fetched it myself from the tap. Ringing bells is a profitless form of exercise in our house.

I brought the water to him and he thanked me. He took from his pocket a small cardboard box and, opening it, extracted a rice paper capsule, which he swallowed with the aid of the water.

'A headache powder,' he explained.

I suddenly wondered whether Hawes might have become addicted to drugs. It would explain a great many of his peculiarities.

'You don't take too many, I hope,' I said.

'No—oh, no. Dr Haydock warned me against that. But it is really wonderful. They bring instant relief.'

Indeed he already seemed calmer and more composed.

He stood up.

'Then you will preach tonight? It's very good of you, sir.'

'Not at all. And I insist on taking the service too. Get along home and rest. No, I won't have any argument. Not another word.'

He thanked me again. Then he said, his eyes sliding past me to the window:

'You—you have been up at Old Hall today, haven't you, sir?'

'Yes.'

'Excuse me—but were you sent for?'

I looked at him in surprise, and he flushed.

'I'm sorry, sir. I—I just thought some new development might have arisen, and that that was why Mrs Protheroe had sent for you.'

I had not the faintest intention of satisfying Hawes' curiosity.

'She wanted to discuss the funeral arrangements and one or two other small matters with me,' I said.

'Oh! That was all. I see.'

I did not speak. He fidgeted from foot to foot, and finally said:

'Mr Redding came to see me last night. I—I can't imagine why.'

'Didn't he tell you?'

'He—he just said he thought he'd look me up. Said it was a bit lonely in the evenings. He's never done such a thing before.'

'Well, he's supposed to be pleasant company,' I said smiling.

'You're very clever at concealing things,' I said, remembering what she had told me in that room less than a week ago, and the ingenuous natural way she had talked.

'Yes, I've always been able to hide things. In a way, I like doing it.'

Her voice held a childlike ring of pleasure in it.

'But it's quite true what I said. I didn't know about Anne, and I wondered why Lawrence was so different, not—well, really not noticing me. I'm not used to it.'

There was a pause.

'You do understand, Len?' said Griselda anxiously.

'Yes,' I said. 'I understand.'

But did I?

Chapter 24

He returned to the Vicarage to find Hawes waiting for me in my study. He was pacing up and down nervously, and when I entered the room he started as though he had been shot.

'You must excuse me,' he said, wiping his forehead. 'My nerves are all to pieces lately.'

'My dear fellow,' I said, 'you positively must get away for a change. We shall have you breaking down altogether, and that will never do.'

'I can't desert my post. No, that is a thing I will never do.'

'It's not a case of desertion. You are ill. I'm sure Haydock would agree with me.'

'Haydock—Haydock. What kind of a doctor is he? An ignorant country practitioner.'

'I think you're unfair to him. He has always been considered a very able man in his profession.'

'Oh! perhaps. Yes, I daresay. But I don't like him. However, that's not what I came to say. I came to ask you if you would be kind enough to preach tonight instead of me. I—I really do not feel equal to it.'

'Why, certainly. I will take the service for you.'

'No, no. I wish to take the service. I am perfectly fit. It is only the idea of getting up in the pulpit, of all those eyes staring at me....'

He shut his eyes and swallowed convulsively.

It was clear to me that there was something very much indeed the matter with Hawes. He seemed aware of my thoughts, for he opened his eyes and said quickly,

'There is nothing really wrong with me. It is just these headaches—these awful racking headaches. I wonder if you could let me have a glass of water.'

'Certainly,' I said.

Chapter 25

found it hard to shake off the impression left by the anonymous letter. Pitch soils. However, I gathered up the other three letters, glanced at my watch and started out.

I wondered very much what this might be that had 'come to the knowledge' of three ladies simultaneously. I took it to be the same piece of news. In this, I was to realize that my psychology was at fault.

I cannot pretend that my calls took me past the police station. My feet gravitated there of their own accord. I was anxious to know whether Inspector Slack had returned from Old Hall.

I found that he had and, further, that Miss Cram had returned with him. The fair Gladys was seated in the police station carrying off matters with a high hand. She denied absolutely having taken the suitcase to the woods.

'Just because one of these gossiping old cats has nothing better to do than look out of her window all night, you go and pitch upon me. She's been mistaken once, remember, when she said she saw me at the end of the lane on the afternoon of the murder, and if she was mistaken then, in daylight, how can she possibly have recognized me by moonlight?

Wicked, it is, the way these old ladies go on down here. Say anything, they will. And me asleep in my bed as innocent as can be. You ought to be ashamed of yourselves, the lot of you.'

'And supposing the landlady of the Blue Boar identifies the suitcase as yours, Miss Cram?'

'If she says anything of the kind, she's wrong. There's no name on it. Nearly everybody's got a suitcase like that. As for poor Dr Stone, accusing him of being a common burglar! And he with a lot of letters after his name.'

'You refuse to give us any explanation, then, Miss Cram?'

'No refusing about it. You've made a mistake, that's all. You and your meddlesome Marples. I won't say a word more—not without my solicitor present. I'm going this minute—unless you're going to arrest me.'

For answer, the Inspector rose and opened the door for her, and, with a toss of the head, Miss Cram walked out.

'That's the line she takes,' said Slack, coming back to his chair. 'Absolute denial. And of course the old lady *may* have been mistaken. No jury would believe you could recognize anyone from that distance on a moonlit night. And of course, as I say, the old lady may have made a mistake.'

'She may,' I said, 'but I don't think she did. Miss Marple is usually right. That's what makes her unpopular.'

The Inspector grinned.

'That's what Hurst says. Lord, these villages!'

'What about the silver, Inspector?'

'Seemed to be perfectly in order. Of course that meant one lot or the other must be a fake. There's a very good man in Much Benham, an authority on old silver. I've phoned over to him and sent a car to fetch him. We'll soon know which is which. Either the burglary was an accomplished fact, or else it was only planned. Doesn't make a frightful lot of difference either way—I mean as far as we're concerned. Robbery's a small business compared with murder. These two aren't concerned with the murder. We'll maybe get a line on him through the girl—that's why I let her go without any more fuss.'

'I wondered,' I said.

'A pity about Mr Redding. It's not often you find a man who goes out of his way to oblige you.'

'I suppose not,' I said smiling slightly.

'Women cause a lot of trouble,' moralized the Inspector.

He sighed and then went on, somewhat to my surprise, 'Of course there's Archer.'

'Oh! I said. 'You've thought of him?'

'Why, naturally, sir, first thing. It didn't need any anonymous letters to put me on his track.'

'Anonymous letters,' I said sharply. 'Did you get one then?'

Her answer came clear and prompt. I thanked her, replaced the receiver and turned to Miss Marple.

'That's very definite. Colonel Protheroe had made arrangements for a man to come down from London on Monday—tomorrow—to make a full valuation. Owing to the Colonel's death, the matter has been put off.'

'Then there *was* a motive,' said Miss Marple softly.

'A motive, yes. But that's all. You forget. When the shot was fired, Dr Stone had just joined the others, or was climbing over the stile in order to do so.'

'Yes,' said Miss Marple thoughtfully. 'So that rules him out.'

'That's what I mean. The sale of such things would take a little time to arrange, or, even if it was arranged, it couldn't be carried through without secrecy. I mean—if the robbery were reported and a hue and cry were raised, well, the things couldn't be marketed at all.'

'I don't quite see what you mean?' I said.

'I know I'm putting it badly.' She became more flustered and apologetic. 'But it seems to me that—that the things couldn't just have been abstracted, so to speak. The only satisfactory thing to do would be to replace these things with copies. Then, perhaps, the robbery wouldn't be discovered for some time.'

'That's a very ingenious idea,' I said.

'It would be the only way to do it, wouldn't it? And if so, of course, as you say, once the substitution had been accomplished, there wouldn't have been any reason for murdering Colonel Protheroe—quite the reverse.'

'Exactly,' I said. 'That's what I said.'

'Yes, but I just wondered—I don't know, of course—and Colonel Protheroe always talked a lot about doing things before he actually did do them, and of course sometimes never did them at all, but he did say—'

'Yes?'

'That he was going to have all his things valued—a man down from London. For probate—no, that's when you're dead—for insurance. Someone told him that was the thing to do. He talked about it a great deal, and the importance of having it done. Of course, I don't know if he had made any actual arrangement, but if he had....'

'I see,' I said slowly.

'Of course, the moment the expert saw the silver, he'd know, and then Colonel Protheroe would remember having shown the things to Dr Stone—I wonder if it was done then—legerdemain, don't they call it? So clever—and then, well, the fat would be in the fire, to use an old-fashioned expression.'

'I see your idea,' I said. 'I think we ought to find out for certain.'

I went once more to the telephone. In a few minutes I was through to Old Hall and speaking to Anne Protheroe.

'No, it's nothing very important. Has the Inspector arrived yet? Oh! well, he's on his way. Mrs Protheroe, can you tell me if the contents of Old Hall were ever valued? What's that you say?'

'That's nothing new, sir. We get a dozen a day, at least. Oh! yes, we were put wise to Archer. As though the police couldn't look out for themselves! Archer's been under suspicion from the first. The trouble of it is, he's got an alibi. Not that it amounts to anything, but it's awkward to get over.'

'What do you mean by its not amounting to anything?' I asked.

'Well, it appears he was with a couple of pals all the afternoon. Not, as I say, that that counts much. Men like Archer and his pals would swear to anything. There's no believing a word they say. *We* know that. But the public doesn't, and the jury's taken from the public, more's the pity. They know nothing, and ten to one believe everything that's said in the witness box, no matter who it is that says it. And of course Archer himself will swear till he's black in the face that he didn't do it.'

'Not so obliging as Mr Redding,' I said with a smile.

'Not he,' said the Inspector, making the remark as a plain statement of fact.

'It is natural, I suppose, to cling to life,' I mused.

'You'd be surprised if you knew the murderers that have got off through the soft heartedness of the jury,' said the Inspector gloomily.

'But do you really think that Archer did it?' I asked.

It has struck me as curious all along that Inspector Slack never seems to have any personal views of his own on the murder. The easiness or difficulty of getting a conviction are the only points that seem to appeal to him.

'I'd like to be a bit surer,' he admitted. 'A fingerprint now, or a footprint, or seen in the vicinity about the time of the crime. Can't risk arresting him without something of that kind. He's been seen round Mr Redding's house once or twice, but he'd say that was to speak to his mother. A decent body, she is. No, on the whole, I'm for the lady. If I could only get definite proof of blackmail—but you can't get definite proof of anything in this crime! It's theory, theory, theory. It's a sad pity that there's not a single spinster lady living along your road, Mr Clement. I bet she'd have seen something if there had been.'

His words reminded me of my calls, and I took leave of him. It was about the solitary instance when I had seen him in a genial mood.

My first call was on Miss Hartnell. She must have been watching for me from the window, for, before I had time to ring, she had opened the front door, and clapping my hand firmly in hers had led me over the threshold.

'So good of you to come. In here. More private.'

We entered a microscopic room, about the size of a hencoop. Miss Hartnell shut the door and, with an air of deep secrecy, waved me to a seat (there were only three). I perceived that she was enjoying herself.

'I'm never one to beat about the bush,' she said in her jolly voice, the latter slightly toned down to meet the requirements of the situation. 'You know how things go the round in a village like this?'

'Unfortunately,' I said, 'I do.'

'I agree with you. Nobody dislikes gossip more than I do. But there it is. I thought it my duty to tell the police Inspector that I'd called on Mrs Lestrangle the afternoon of the murder and that she was out. I don't expect to be thanked for doing my duty; I just do it. Ingratitude is what you meet with first and last in this life. Why only yesterday that impudent Mrs Baker—'

'Yes, yes,' I said hoping to avert the usual tirade. 'Very sad, very sad. But you were saying.'

'The lower classes don't know who are their best friends,' said Miss Hartnell. 'I always say a word in season when I'm visiting. Not that I'm ever thanked for it.'

'You were telling the Inspector about your call upon Mrs Lestrangle,' I prompted.

'Exactly—and, by the way, he didn't thank me. Said he'd ask for information when he wanted it—not those words exactly, but that was the spirit. There's a different class of men in the police force nowadays.'

'Very probably,' I said. 'But you were going on to say something?'

'I decided that this time I wouldn't go near any wretched Inspector. After all, a clergyman is a gentleman—at least some are,' she added.

I gathered that the qualification was not intended to include me.

'If I can help you in any way,' I began.

'It's a matter of duty,' said Miss Hartnell and closed her mouth with a snap. 'I don't want to have to say these things. No one likes it less. But duty is duty.'

I waited.

'The trencher salts,' she exclaimed. 'Colonel Protheroe's trencher salts, and the Charles II tazza. Did you ever hear of such a thing?'

The Inspector had got very red.

'So that was the game,' he muttered. 'Robbery. But I can't make it out. There's been no mention of these things being missing.'

'Perhaps they haven't discovered the loss,' I suggested. 'I presume these valuable things would not have been kept out in common use. Colonel Protheroe probably kept them locked away in a safe.'

'I must investigate this,' said the Inspector. 'I'll go right up to Old Hall now. So that's why our Dr Stone made himself scarce. What with the murder and one thing and another, he was afraid we'd get wind of his activities. As likely as not his belongings might have been searched. He got the girl to hide them in the wood with a suitable change of clothing. He meant to come back by a roundabout route and go off with them one night while she stayed here to disarm suspicion. Well, there's one thing to the good. This lets him out over the murder. He'd nothing to do with that. Quite a different game.'

He repacked the suitcase and took his departure, refusing Miss Marple's offer of a glass of sherry.

'Well, that's one mystery cleared up,' I said with a sigh. 'What Slack says is quite true; there are no grounds for suspecting him of the murder. Everything's accounted for quite satisfactorily.'

'It really would seem so,' said Miss Marple. 'Although one never can be quite certain, can one?'

'There's a complete lack of motive,' I pointed out. 'He'd got what he came for and was clearing out.'

'Y—es.'

She was clearly not quite satisfied, and I looked at her in some curiosity. She hastened to answer my inquiring gaze with a kind of apologetic eagerness.

'I've no doubt I am *quite* wrong. I'm so stupid about these things. But I just wondered—I mean this silver is very valuable, is it not?'

'A tazza sold the other day for over a thousand pounds, I believe.'

'I mean—it's not the value of the metal.'

'No, it's what one might call a connoisseur's value.'